

**Software Saviours**

Possibly the best way to check your security is to use the very tools someone would use to gain unauthorised access to your WLAN. Here's a short list of tools that are built either to attack or defend:

AirSnort: A WLAN sniffer tool that recovers encryption keys by passively monitoring transmissions. It calculates the encryption key after it has received enough packets. It can be downloaded from <http://snipurl.com/dgif>

WEPCrack: This uses the latest RC4 key scheduling to crack a WLAN's WEP code. Get it from <http://snipurl.com/dgih>

NetStumbler: This tool lets you 'discover' any WLANs or access points in your vicinity. This tool can also be used for your site survey, as it will inform you of any existing WLANs that may cause interference or help you know your signal strength at different points. It can be downloaded from <http://snipurl.com/dgij>

Internet Scanner: The Internet Scanner provides an automated network vulnerability assessment. It performs distributed or event-driven probes of network services, operating systems, routers/switches, servers, firewalls, and application routers to identify potential risks. Try an evaluation version at <http://snipurl.com/dgil>

Wireless Scanner: This detects and analyses your WLAN access points and clients. It identifies and reports unauthorised and misconfigured devices. Try it by going to <http://snipurl.com/dgim>.

BlackIce PC Protection: This is a personal firewall for laptops and Wi-Fi-enabled desktops with the ability to protect you from intrusions and client-to-client attacks. Download a trial from <http://snipurl.com/dgio>

You should also visit www.iss.net, the homepage of Internet Security Systems, a leading security consultant to companies and governments world-wide. Here, you will find some of the tools mentioned above, and also many security solutions for enterprises, educational institutions and even governments.

If you are paranoid about security, program each access point to filter requests by MAC addresses

access point manufacturers are well known, and hence these should be changed immediately. Make sure you don't use your company name or initials as the SSID.

Also, you must enable encryption of signals so that unauthorised users cannot use wireless Ethernet sniffers to spy on the network. Even the 128-bit WEP encryption is fallible. For details on problems that WEP faces, visit <http://snipurl.com/dggs>. The latest 802.11i standard addresses these problems and is recommended for its use of AES encryption.

Turn off broadcast pings to make access points invisible to sniffers and simple network analysis tools. If you are paranoid about security, program each access point to filter requests by MAC addresses, though you will need to add every single wireless device's MAC address to every access point in the network. Or simply secure your network by information overload. Once you set up WLAN, go to <http://snipurl.com/dgh4> and download FakeAP. When you run this, any intruder will see thousands of access points—so your actual access points are hidden by vast numbers.

In Sum

Though there are costs involved, and security at stake, the fact is that as wireless technologies get faster, better and more secure, Wi-Fi could give your business a welcome boost of steroids. In fact, in certain cases, you might find that Wi-Fi is the only option.

Look out for the Fast Track book on Wireless Networking, free with the May 2005 issue of *Digit!* ■

robert_smith@thinkdigit.com

1 Col Ad